

Main

Report Name (Org_Country_Year_Report Type)

ILRI_Kenya_2024-25_3-month Report (2)

Fellowship Organization

International Livestock Research Institute (ILRI)

Fellowship City

Nairobi

Fellowship Country

Kenya

Fellowship Start Date

07/15/2024

Anticipated Fellowship End Date

07/14/2025

What is your fellowship title/role?

Communications Fellow

What are your primary responsibilities?

Supported conduction of evidence synthesis of all climate-related research published by CGIAR over 10+ years & coauthor of forthcoming publication on CGIAR's global climate impact.

Coordinated 8 training sessions on systematic review methods and mapping to support capacity building of CGIAR scientists & partners conducting research on food security and climate change.

Engaged Platform's community of practice by managing biweekly roundup of the latest climate change publications, monthly webinars, and biweekly online discussions via Dgroups.

Responsible for developing and sharing biweekly roundup of the latest climate literature and linking the publications to CGIAR's portfolio.

Produced a four-part video series focused on the impact of climate change on the agri-food sector.

Developed graphics and social media content for showcasing CGIAR activities in the climate and agri-food sector.

I receive adequate direction and support to perform my fellowship responsibilities.

Agree

Did you receive any sort of orientation, handover or onboarding when you started your fellowship?

Yes

Please describe your orientation/onboarding and note who handled it.

On my first day at ILRI, I met with CapDev staff to go over the fellowship paperwork and expectations. Then my team's Executive Assistant gave me a tour of the campus, helped me get my equipment, introduced me to my team members, and showed me where my desk was. There was also a mandatory security training and I had to get a physical done at the hospital.

For handover, I had two very brief meetings:

- 1) I met with my manager where she explained very broadly what types of comms products that the team produces for the Climate Platform. We briefly talked about which of these products I'd work on but didn't get into any specific on the "how-tos".
- 2) I met with one other coworker who I was taking over one of the Platform's newsletters from. This was very helpful and she walked me through the development process of the newsletter step-by-step.

No fellow has been at this specific position with the Climate Platform before so there were no formal handover notes.

If you did not receive any kind of orientation, what information or guidance were you provided at the start of your fellowship?**Describe a representative day at work.**

I Uber into the office by either 8 or 9am. I usually grab coffee at the coffee stand in my building and some samosas or mandazi for a light breakfast. I head up to my desk which is on the second floor of Mara House at ILRI - it is the farthest building from the campus entrance before entering the farms (which require special access). I set up at my desk in a shared space with PhD students, check my emails and teams, and start working on my tasks for the day. The shared space is very quiet so I usually step into a meeting room if I need to take a meeting.

Around 1pm everyday, I usually meet up with my co-fellow for lunch at the cafeteria which is about a 5 minute walk from the building. Lunch is usually an hour. After lunch, I head back to my desk and continue working on tasks until 4:30pm. At 4:30pm, I pack up and walk up to the ILRI bus to go home. The buses leave by 4:40pm and it takes around 20-40 minutes to get to my apartment depending on traffic.

On average, how many hours per week do you work?

40

How would you describe your effectiveness in your fellowship post so far?

Effective

Please briefly describe 1-2 specific projects that you have undertaken or accomplishments you have made so far.

Systematic Review Methods Training - I coordinate trainings for CGIAR scientists and NARES partners on methods for conducting systematic reviews and mapping. So far, I have coordinate four of the eight trainings that we are holding in 2024.

Video Series - I am producing a four-part animated video series on climate change and agri-food issues including: loss and damage, adaptation in the agri-food sector, carbon credits, and carbon dioxide removal

I've also just written my first blog post, put out 8+ editions of the newsletter I manage, and completed a literature screening of 4,000+ publications for the evidence synthesis we are doing.

What is your organization's work culture like?

What is your office environment like? Please comment on the size and structure of the office(s) where you do most of your work.

ILRI is a very large campus that covers around 60 acres or so. I am located at Mara House which is the farthest building from the main entrance of ILRI before you enter Mazingira, the part with the farms. It is full of shared working spaces, private offices, conference/meeting rooms, two kitchens, and a coffee stand where you can buy coffee and snacks. This is nice since Mara House is about a 5 minute uphill walk from the main ILRI buildings and the cafeteria. I am the first fellow to be put in this building - previous fellows all worked out of ILRI's infocentre/library. I sit on the second floor of Mara House in a shared space with 8-10 PhD students - although I will be moved to a new private shared office with one of my coworkers in a building called Swing One soon.

To whom do you report?

Supervisor: Director, CGIAR Climate Impact Platform

Line manager: Communications Manager, CGIAR Climate Impact Platform

Have you had an initial check-in with your supervisor to set up a work plan and to set goals for your work during your fellowship year?

Yes

Was this meeting helpful in understanding your role and setting goals for your fellowship year?

Yes it was helpful although for awhile the tasks I was given did not really align with the workplan.

Please explain why you have not met with your supervisor and if you have plans to do so going forward.

Please briefly indicate 3-5 professional goals you have for the rest of your fellowship year. Your professional goals should align with your work plan.

Co-author CGIAR evidence synthesis

Build video editing proficiency

Write at least 5 blogs

Have at least 1 coffee chat per month with staff working in my area of interest

Build communications portfolio (graphic design, blog writing, etc.)

How often do you check in with your supervisor?

Weekly

Have you had an opportunity to travel for work so far?

Yes

Describe this travel opportunity. Include location(s) and a brief description of the purpose of the trip(s).

I had the opportunity to go to the Netherlands for one week. I went to the University of Groningen to visit a Professor who we are contracting to do part of the analysis for the evidence synthesis of CGIAR work.

I feel adequately prepared for my position's professional responsibilities.

Agree

Please briefly explain your response.

I feel very adequately prepared for the communications related tasks that I have been given since I have a good amount of experience in comms leading up to the fellowship.

However, the first few months of the fellowship involved a lot of research related tasks - conducting literature reviews, writing a protocol for our research, creating a ROSES diagram. I was very unfamiliar with all of these things so I did not feel like I was the best person to support with them. This was also surprising since I was interviewed and onboarded as a full communications fellow. But I am grateful I had the chance to work on them as I think experience with these tasks will be really useful for gradschool.

How did you travel to your host country and site? Please be specific

ILRI purchased my ticket for me and I flew on Air France from San Francisco to Paris, Paris to Nairobi. They will also book my return flight for next July for me. I am not sure how much the ticket costs round trip.

What kind of visa/ permit do you have or applied for?

Right now I just have an eTA travel visa but I am applying for an Internship Pass.

How did you obtain (or are obtaining) your visa or permit?

I am still trying to obtain an Internship Pass.

Did you apply for and receive your visa / permit before heading to your host country or after arriving?

I applied before my arrival for the eTA. I am still in the process of obtaining an Internship Pass visa.

What costs were associated with obtaining your visa or permit?

\$30

Did you pay the visa / permit costs or were they covered by your organization?

I paid.

Are you still having challenges obtaining your visa/ permit?

Yes

If yes, please explain further

ILRI has been very slow with following up on the progress of my visa. The Kenyan immigration website was also down for several weeks which delayed things and now its been over a month since I uploaded all of my documentation, and no progress has been made. ILRI says "These things take time" but I know that one of the other fellows in Nairobi has already gotten her visa and I've been here longer than she has.

g) Do you have any suggestions to help future Fellows navigate the visa / permit application process?

I suggest making sure you have all your paperwork ready and prepare to pester the ILRI CapDev department frequently to make sure things

What vaccinations were you required to obtain prior to your departure? How much did your vaccinations cost? Did you get a yellow fever vaccination?

Technically none. I already had a vaccination for yellow fever and cholera. I renewed my typhoid vaccine, got the chikungunya vaccine (although this is definitely not needed), and a prescription for malaria.

How was your arrival and first week in your host country? Any improvements that could streamline the assimilation process for future Fellows?

My arrival was fairly smooth. When I arrived in Nairobi, ILRI sent a driver to pick me up from the airport and take me to my Airbnb. I stayed at the Airbnb for 3 or 4 nights before moving into my apartment. I suggest that future Fellows look into what they will need to do for getting a new sim card before arriving. It is inconvenient to not have a Kenyan number here so that is something that should be a priority.

Is housing provided by and/or paid for by your organization? Please explain.

Housing is not provided or paid for by ILRI. They give me my monthly stipend and I was responsible for finding housing and for paying my rent.

Do you live in a location that is more urban or rural?

Very Urban

Please describe your living environment

Nairobi is a huge city and very urban. I just moved to a new apartment in Westlands which has a very high international population. It's about a 25 minute drive from ILRI and close to a lot of cafes, embassies, shopping centers, etc. It's a pretty peaceful neighborhood and a lot of families live here.

How do you typically travel between your home and your work? How much does your daily transportation cost and how long is your commute?

ILRI has a bus that employees can take to and from work. The bus comes very early in the morning though so I usually take an uber instead. It usually costs between 500-600 shillings. I do take the bus on the way home though. The commute is about 25-30 minutes.

If you live in a more rural area, what are the closest urban areas you can travel to for shopping, airport, larger medical centers, etc.?

N/A

How is the weather in your host country? What season are you presently in?

Nairobi has really great weather so far. It was actually pretty cold when I first arrived and could be in the low 50 degrees F at ILRI in the mornings. Now it's usually between 70-80 degrees during the day and very sunny and warm. We are currently in the dry season.

What is the appropriate clothing for work and outside of work at your fellowship post and in your community in general?

ILRI doesn't have strict clothing requirements - some people dress very formally (suits and ties) while others are very casual (jeans and t-shirts). I usually erre on the side of being more formal and shoot for business casual, especially if I have any in-person meetings. Outside the post I wear pretty much anything I used to wear in the US, just a tad more modest. I don't wear anything too short or revealing.

How have you been spending your free time?

Nairobi has a TON of events all of the time. In my free time I usually hang out with the other fellows and my friends, go to happy hours, live music events/concerts, I volunteer at a local animal shelter called KSCPA, take Swahili lessons, cafe hop, hike, take weekend trips, etc. I am also joining a tennis club with one of the previous PiAf fellows in Nairobi. Pretty much the opportunities to socialize are endless and people are generally really friendly and eager to meet new people.

I've been able to successfully navigate my personal/social life both back at home and at my fellowship post.

Strongly Agree

Please briefly explain your response below.

Having the other Nairobi fellows as a built-in social group has helped a lot with navigating my personal/social life. Going to events and talking to new people has also helped. I've had to become more intentional with keeping in touch with my friends and family back home though.

Would you say you live and work in a safe area?

Yes, I'd say in general I live and work in safe areas. Westlands is a more affluent area but I still do not go walking around at night. The ILRI campus is very safe and has high security. I don't walk around outside of the campus though. Although I think the surrounding neighborhood is safe, you never see any foreigners or internationals there.

What precautions do you take to ensure your safety?

I don't walk around at night and stay aware of my surroundings. I take Ubers directly to my destinations and make sure not to keep my phone exposed when out in public. I also share my location with another fellows as an extra precaution.

What has been your experience with crime so far? (Please note that any security or safety concerns or incidents should be reported directly to PiAf staff per PiAf safety and security protocol.)

I personally have not had any experience with crime so far but my roommate who is also a PiAf fellow had her phone stolen from her purse when we were out one night.

Describe the incidence of crime and the general security situation within your city/town. Could you recommend specific areas future Fellows might consider for safe housing? What about areas that should be avoided?

Crime is something to consider in Nairobi. It's known that theft is very high here and people getting their phones stolen is very common. It was one of the first things that pretty much all of my coworkers told me when I first arrived and they said to make sure that I never hold my phone out in the open or set it down when I'm out in public or walking around. It's also known that a lot of robberies happen at night so it's not safe to walk around, especially alone. Even during the day, it's definitely the norm to uber everywhere even if the place your going is a short distance. Safe neighborhoods are Kilimani, Kileleshwa, Lavington, Westlands, Riverside, etc. Not safe ones are Eastleigh, Kibera, Kawangware.

Please refer back to the goals you set for yourself before orientation. Are you working towards these goals? Have you met any of them? Changed any of them? Please explain.

My goals that I set at the beginning were:

Immerse myself into the local community to learn about Kenyan culture, learn Swahili, and build community relationships.

Embrace discomfort & seek out new perspectives, challenges, experiences.

Consistently capture my fellowship experience (blog, social media, journaling, etc.)

I think I have been successful working towards all of my goals. I am actively learning about Kenyan culture from my cofellow and coworkers, learning Swahili, building relationships with people outside of PiAf and ILRI, challenging myself both at work and outside it, and I also started a blog and capturing my fellowship experience.

Do you have any frustrations with your living arrangements, your work or your life outside of work?

My biggest frustration is that there seems to be a disconnect with expectations of PiAf fellows at ILRI. Some people on my team thought I was a current student at Princeton and that the fellowship was the equivalent of an "internship". This was different from my expectation that the fellowship was meant to be considered as a full-time position with the company and not an internship. I also am coming to the fellowship from a full-time job so it was surprising when my team thought that I was still in school and frustrating that I was being given low-level work at first.

There is also a noticeable difference in the treatment that I get vs. the treatment that my co-fellow, who is part of the NEXUS program, gets. There is a lot of inequity even in the type of equipment we get (I was given my own personal work space with a monitor, laptop, keyboard etc., and he was given only a laptop), how many days off we get (I was told I get 2 days off per month but he was told he gets none), how much we get paid (my stipend is not taxed but my co-fellow is because he is Kenyan). We both work for different teams so some of the differences are because of that but I think PiAf should take steps to reconcile the inequities especially as the NEXUS program continues to develop moving forward.

Has there been anything that you have needed but have not been able to locate or acquire?

No - I've not had an issue getting anything in Nairobi.

How have you dealt with "culture shock"?

Transitioning to life in Nairobi has actually been very smooth for me but one thing I did not expect is how things move here - especially with the visa process. I didn't expect having to follow up with people so much on things that they would said they would do. It has also happened at work where someone will say they have done something that they promised to do but didn't actually do it. For example, it's been over a month since I was told I was being moved into an office with my coworker but the person that was supposed to move in my desk/equipment still hasn't. When my coworker asked him about it he said that I told him that I didn't want to move so he didn't bring the desk - even though I've never once talked to him before...Then a week later he said that my desk was all set up but when I went to check the office there was nothing there...

What about your experience thus far has been the most...surprising?

How much there is to do here! Again, the number of events is endless and there is always something to do.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...challenging?

The most challenging thing has been navigating my role at ILRI given the ambiguity on what my team expected from me joining vs. what I expected. Another challenge has been being far away from family and missing out on big moments and not being able to help with challenges back home.

What are the top 3 things you miss the most from your home country or the U.S.?

Food! Mexican food, In-n-out, Krispy Kreme, takis & hot cheetos! You can find them here sometimes but they are VERY expensive
Being able to drive!
Being able to walk around town/not worry about having my phone stolen

What are the top 3 things about life in your host country that beat out life in your home country or the U.S.?

Work culture - the work environment feels a lot more relaxed here and
Activities available - endless events, places to travel to, etc.
Nature - safaris, coast, etc.

How is your stipend being paid?

Monthly, USD, direct deposit into US account

How are you receiving your stipend funds?

Wire

Did you raise funds to cover part of your fellowship expenses?

I was working full-time for two years prior to the fellowship so I have my own savings that helped me finance the move to Kenya. My family has also contributed to helping pay some of my expenses.

Please list any additional one-time or infrequent expenses not included in your monthly budget below.

Monthly Budget

Rent \$320.00	Utilities \$0.00	Furnishings \$0.00	Phone \$25.00	Home Security \$0.00	Internet \$0.00
Transportation \$115.00	Fitness \$5.00	Entertainment \$200.00	Groceries \$100.00	House Cleaning \$0.00	Eating Out \$150.00
Medications \$0.00	Additional Health Insurance \$0.00	Travel \$400.00	Laundry \$0.00	Other \$200.00	Total Monthly Budget (Minus Entertainment & Travel) 915.00
Specify "Other" Savings per month					

Final Thoughts

Please briefly explain your response about Orientation.

I think more could have been said about how PiAf communicates the expectations for a fellowship post with the host organizations. Again, I was very confused why my team thought I was either an intern or a student when I was under the impression that PiAf has extensive conversations with them about what the fellowship is and that it should be treated as a full-time position.

I understand also that it's difficult for PiAf to do country-specific programming but I think this is a detriment to how prepared the fellows are before coming. With the differences in pay that my fellow and I are getting, I think more needs to be done on PiAf's side on how a fellow's stipend will be impacted by local taxes or at the very least be more clear on how fellow's should discuss this with their host organizations BEFORE starting at the post.

Is there anything in particular that PiAf could cover at orientation that would have better prepared you for your fellowship post? Please specify.

- 1) Been clearer on if the fellowship will be considered as an internship vs. full time job at the host organization
- 2) Include country-specific info on how fellow's stipends will be impacted by local taxes

Are you receiving sufficient support, materials and information from the Princeton in Africa office? What could we improve?

I think more involvement on pushing the orgs to keep making progress with the visa applications would be helpful.

As we plan the upcoming PiAf Retreat, we hope to incorporate some Fellow suggestions into our programming. What are some topics or sessions you would like to see at the Retreat? (We appreciate your feedback however, we may not be able to accommodate all suggestions or requests this year.)

N/A